

G. Zuntz also recognized all of this. “Modern criticism stops before the barrier of the second century; the age, so it seems, of unbounded liberties with the text”.<sup>1</sup>

Kilpatrick goes on to argue that the creation of new variants ceased by about 200 AD because it became impossible to ‘sell’ them. He discusses some of Origen’s attempts at introducing a change into the text, and proceeds:

Origen’s treatment of Matthew 19:19 is significant in two other ways. First he was probably the most influential commentator of the Ancient Church and yet his conjecture at this point seems to have influenced only one manuscript of a local version of the New Testament. The Greek tradition is apparently quite unaffected by it. From the third century onward even an Origen could not effectively alter the text.

This brings us to the second significant point—his date. From the early third century onward the freedom to alter the text which had obtained earlier can no longer be practiced. Tatian is the last author to make deliberate changes in the text of whom we have explicit information. Between Tatian and Origen Christian opinion had so changed that it was no longer possible to make changes in the text whether they were harmless or not.<sup>2</sup>

He feels this attitude was a reaction against the re-handling of the text by the second-century heretics. Certainly there had been a great hue and cry, and whatever the reason it does appear that little further damage was done after AD 200.<sup>3</sup> However, I certainly disagree with Kilpatrick’s “freedom to alter the text which had obtained earlier”; there was no such ‘freedom’, it was the perversity of enemies of the Truth.

#### The aberrant text forms

The extent of the textual difficulties of the 2<sup>nd</sup> century can easily be exaggerated. Nevertheless, the evidence cited does prove that aberrant forms of the NT text were produced. Naturally, some of those text forms may have acquired a local and temporary currency, but they could scarcely become more than eddies along the edge of the ‘majority’ river. Recall that

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<sup>1</sup> G. Zuntz, *The Text of the Epistles* (London: Oxford University Press, 1953), p. 11.

<sup>2</sup> Kilpatrick, “Atticism and the Text of the Greek New Testament”, *Neutestamentliche Aufsätze* (Regensburg: Verlag Friedrich Pustet, 1963), pp. 129-30.

<sup>3</sup> I believe we may reasonably understand that significant variants that first appear at a later date, within extant MSS, had actually been created much earlier.